

# UPSC Civil Services (Main) Simulation GS-IV

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

**Q1. (a) "A system of morality which is based on relative emotional values is a mere illusion, a thoroughly vulgar conception which has nothing sound in it and nothing true." - Socrates. What does this quotation mean to you? (b) Discuss why a positive attitude, though necessary, is not a sufficient condition for ethical conduct in civil service. Illustrate with the concept of the attitude-behaviour gap.**

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (274 words; practice model, not official): (a) The quotation warns that volatile feeling, personal preference or group sentiment cannot by themselves provide a stable moral standard. Public decisions need reasons that can be examined for consistency, factual accuracy, impartiality and generalisability. Otherwise prejudice may be relabelled as sincere emotion. A district administration should not prohibit an inter-community marriage merely because a local majority feels offended. Mill distinguishes offence from harm, while Kant asks whether the discriminatory maxim could be universalised. Socratic questioning exposes whether the asserted value survives rational scrutiny. The statement should not be read as making emotion ethically worthless. Empathy reveals suffering, remorse can motivate correction and compassion improves implementation. Emotion supplies morally relevant information, but reason and public justification must evaluate it. Provenance also requires caution: the exact sentence has not been located in classical sources. (b) A positive attitude provides a civil servant with constructive orientation toward duty, fairness and citizen welfare. It shapes how rules are interpreted, how crises are managed and how vulnerable persons are treated. In this sense it is necessary for ethical administration. However, LaPiere's 1934 study established that stated attitudes predict specific behaviour poorly. An officer who sincerely values transparency may still withhold information when a superior exerts pressure, when career incentives discourage disclosure, or when institutional norms reward silence. This is the attitude-behaviour gap: situational forces and institutional design can override even strongly held positive attitudes. For example, in a revenue department, officers may declare commitment to impartiality yet allow political recommendations to influence file disposal because the transfer-posting system punishes non-compliance. The verdict is that attitude is the starting point of ethical conduct, but institutional design is its guarantor.

**Q2. (a) "The Right to Information Act is not all about citizens' empowerment alone, it essentially redefines the concept of accountability." Discuss. (b) Distinguish between laws and rules. Discuss the role of ethics in formulating them.**

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (265 words; practice model, not official): (a) RTI empowers a citizen to seek existing records, but its deeper contribution is to change the relationship between public authority and citizen. Section 4 requires organised records and proactive disclosure; Sections 6 and 7 create a time-bound request route; Section 19 supplies appeal; and Section 20 can attach personal consequence to specified PIO failures. The authority, rather than the applicant, must justify withholding under a statutory exemption. This makes decisions traceable. Tender criteria, beneficiary lists, expenditure and recorded reasons can be compared with law and actual delivery. MKSS-style verification of muster rolls illustrates how information becomes evidence for social accountability. Yet disclosure alone is not complete accountability: a competent forum must hear, judge, correct and remedy the revealed failure. Privacy, security and other protected interests also require narrow, reasoned treatment, including severability. (b) Laws are publicly enacted, generally binding norms backed by state authority and formal sanctions. Rules are more specific operational prescriptions framed under law or within institutions to guide recurring conduct. Both regulate external behaviour, but legality alone does not establish moral legitimacy. Ethics shapes their purpose, content and procedure. Dignity prevents a welfare rule from humiliating beneficiaries; equality rejects discriminatory eligibility; proportionality limits excessive penalties; transparency and participation make rule-making accountable. Kant's distinction is useful: law can demand outward compliance, while ethics asks whether the underlying maxim respects persons and could be universally justified. For example, a lawful biometric rule may still be unethical if it excludes elderly citizens without alternatives. Ethics would require exception channels, data protection and grievance redress. Conversely, ethical aspirations require clear rules to avoid arbitrary discretion.

**Q3. (a) Carl von Clausewitz once said, "War is a diplomacy by other means." Critically analyse the above statement in the present context of contemporary geo-political conflict. (b) An independent and empowered social audit mechanism is an absolute must in every sphere of public service, including judiciary, to ensure performance, accountability and ethical conduct. Elaborate.**

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (278 words; practice model, not official): (a) Clausewitz's proposition explains war as organised force serving political purpose rather than violence wholly separate from statecraft. Contemporary conflicts confirm that territory, deterrence, alliances and

bargaining objectives shape military action. Yet describing war as diplomacy can normalise coercion and obscure the moral change created when persuasion becomes lethal force. Ethically, policy purpose cannot remove the UN Charter concern for sovereignty or the *jus ad bellum* tests of legitimate authority, necessity, last resort and proportionality. Once conflict begins, *jus in bello* independently requires distinction, precautions and proportionality; civilians cannot become instruments for negotiation. Nuclear risk, autonomous systems, information warfare, displacement and attacks affecting food or energy networks make escalation increasingly difficult to control. The statement is therefore descriptively powerful but normatively incomplete. War may pursue policy, but ethics and law must discipline both the purpose and the means. (b) Social audit converts citizens from passive recipients into participants who test official records against lived outcomes. Independence from the implementing body, proactive disclosure, access to records, verification with users and a public hearing can reveal exclusion, false reporting and poor performance that ordinary files conceal. Its accountability value depends on follow-up. Findings need a time-bound action-taken report, correction or compensation, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and protection against intimidation. For MGNREGA, workers can compare job cards, muster rolls, wages and physical works. In other public services, the design must respect confidentiality, decisional independence and lawful review; citizen participation cannot become mob pressure on judges or adjudication. Thus the proposition is strongest as a demand for independent public verification and enforceable response, adapted to institutional function. Disclosure without competent judgment and remedy remains transparency, not complete accountability.

**Q4. (a) "In law, a man is guilty when he violates the rights of others. In ethics, he is guilty if he only thinks of doing so." - Immanuel Kant. What does this quotation convey to you in the present context? (b) Distinguish transparency, disclosure, information sharing and accountability in public administration.**

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (269 words; practice model, not official): (a) The quotation distinguishes the external threshold of legal liability from the deeper ethical appraisal of maxims, intentions and cultivated dispositions. Law normally requires an act, attempt or legally cognisable violation; ethics can condemn a settled intention even when circumstances prevent its execution. An officer who resolves to favour a contractor has already abandoned impartiality although cancellation of the tender may prevent criminal loss. A code of ethics therefore addresses integrity, motive and conflict disclosure beyond the completed acts prohibited by a conduct code. This reflects Kant's broader distinction between acting from duty and merely conforming outwardly to duty. The statement must not become a doctrine of guilt for intrusive or passing thoughts. Infield's reconstructed lecture says 'harboured the thought' and then discusses impure dispositions, implying endorsement or cultivation of wrongful intent. Ethical self-scrutiny supplements, but does not replace, legal due process. (b) Transparency is the continuing visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and outcomes to appropriate scrutiny. Disclosure is a particular act of releasing specified information, proactively or on request. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information for a defined function; it may occur between departments without becoming public. Accountability is the relationship in which an identified actor explains conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of correction, remedy or consequence. The distinctions are practical. Publishing a tender is disclosure and may strengthen transparency. Sharing verified bidder debarment data with another authorised buyer is purpose-bound information sharing. If an audit body examines the award, hears the officer and orders correction, accountability is completed. Conversely, a data dump without reasons may disclose much while remaining opaque.

**Q5. (a) "The true rule, in determining to embrace, or reject any thing, is not whether it has any evil in it; but whether it has more evil than good...especially of governmental policy...our best judgment of the preponderance between them is continually demanded." - Abraham Lincoln. What does this quotation mean to you in the present context? (b) Distinguish Section 17A approval from Section 19 sanction under the Prevention of Corruption Act. Why does the distinction matter?**

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (258 words; practice model, not official): (a) Lincoln's quotation recognises that public policy usually involves mixed consequences rather than choices between perfect good and pure evil. Ethical judgment therefore requires disciplined comparison of benefits, harms, probabilities, affected groups, duration and reversibility instead of moral absolutism or political slogan. A hydroelectric project may provide clean energy and employment while displacing a tribal community and damaging ecology. Millian reasoning compares aggregate welfare, but Rawls asks whether the design protects and benefits the least advantaged. Kant prevents the displaced from being treated merely as compensable costs, while Aristotle requires proportionate, context-sensitive implementation. The quotation does not mean that every right can be traded for a larger numerical gain. Constitutional rights, informed consent, rehabilitation and environmental limits remain ethical floors. (b) Section 17A and Section 19 protect different procedural stages. Section 17A requires previous approval before a police officer conducts an enquiry, inquiry or investigation into a PC Act allegation relatable to a recommendation made or decision taken by a serving or former public servant in discharge of official functions. It is rank-neutral, prescribes three months plus a recorded one-month extension, and excludes on-the-spot arrest while accepting or attempting to accept an undue advantage. Section 19, by contrast, prevents a court from taking cognizance of listed offences alleged against a public servant without previous sanction of the competent government or authority. Its list is Sections 7, 10, 11, 13 and 15; it is not a universal list of all PC Act offences. The distinction matters because conflation can either obstruct lawful preliminary action or erase a statutory safeguard.

**Q6. Compare the ethical significance of Manjunath Shanmugam and Satyendra Dubey without reducing either case to a hero story.**

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (126 words; practice model, not official): Both officers demonstrate integrity and moral courage against organised wrongdoing: Manjunath challenged fuel adulteration, while Dubey exposed corruption in highway construction. Their deaths prove that individual virtue can reveal serious misconduct but cannot supply its own protection. The institutional mechanism is therefore central: a safe authorised channel, identity separation, threat assessment, independent evidence custody, anti-retaliation remedies and time-bound investigation. The unresolved legal position matters. An official 2025 Lok Sabha answer stated that the Whistle Blowers Protection Act, 2014 had not been brought into force; PIDPI remains an administrative route, not an equivalent statutory guarantee. The limitation is equally important: protection cannot make an allegation self-proving. Fair verification and hearing remain necessary. The cases support protected courage joined to institutional duty, not martyrdom as a governance model.

**Q7. Is it possible for emotional intelligence to help in overcoming a crisis of conscience without compromising the ethical stand that one may like to take? Critically examine.**

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (139 words; practice model, not official): A crisis of conscience arises when personal values, professional duty and situational pressures pull in conflicting directions. Emotional intelligence helps navigate this without ethical compromise through three mechanisms. First, self-awareness enables the officer to name the conflict precisely rather than experiencing it as diffuse anguish. Second, self-regulation prevents the emotional turmoil from producing impulsive action or paralysis - the officer remains composed enough to reason through options. Third, social skill allows transparent communication of the chosen course to stakeholders, converting a solitary moral burden into a documented, accountable decision. Critical examination requires acknowledging limits. EI provides the psychological infrastructure for managing the crisis but does not itself supply the ethical standard. The officer still needs a moral framework - deontological, consequentialist or virtue-based - to determine which stand to take. EI without ethical grounding can produce composed capitulation rather than principled resolution.

**Q8. Rajesh, an administrative officer in a public-sector undertaking, is asked to procure stationery from a particular vendor. The total estimate exceeds his delegated limit, while splitting orders to avoid higher sanction is a common but rule-violating practice. What are his options, the ethical issues and the most appropriate course? Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.**

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (188 words; practice model, not official): Rajesh can split the requirement, delay action without explanation, seek open competition within his power by artificially reducing scope, or consolidate the genuine need and route it to the competent higher authority. The first three evade responsibility. The ethical issues include financial propriety, possible vendor favour, conflict created by appraisal dependence, obedience versus integrity, auditability, fair competition and protection of public money. He should verify the total requirement and applicable procurement method, record that one demand cannot be fragmented merely to avoid sanction, prepare neutral specifications and market-based estimates, and submit the consolidated proposal to the competent authority. For goods, GFR Rule 157 supplies the precise anti-piecemeal rule; works or services require their applicable category framework. He should seek written confirmation of any contrary direction and avoid privately accusing the superior without evidence. If pressure persists, Rajesh should use the authorised finance, procurement or vigilance review route while preserving records. Promotion anxiety cannot convert delegated power into ownership. The preferred option protects both timely purchase and institutional scrutiny; resignation is premature while lawful internal remedies remain. The decision, conflict disclosures and approvals should remain available for independent audit.

**Q9. A humanitarian donor offers urgent climate-disaster assistance to an Indian Ocean island state but ties it to unrelated procurement preferences, exclusive access to strategic infrastructure and donor control over beneficiary data. Evaluate the options and propose an ethical aid compact. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.**

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (238 words; practice model, not official): The immediate duty is to save life, shelter displaced people and restore essential services. Stakeholders include affected residents, vulnerable minorities, the recipient government, local firms, donor taxpayers, humanitarian agencies and future citizens whose sovereignty and data rights may be impaired. The dilemmas are urgency versus informed choice, accountability versus domination, and short-term relief versus dependency. The recipient could accept all conditions, reject the package, seek alternative donors, or negotiate a separated compact. Unqualified acceptance accelerates relief but converts vulnerability into leverage, distorts procurement and exposes sensitive data. Rejection protects autonomy but may leave preventable suffering. Waiting solely for alternatives may be too slow. The ethical course is to accept or request immediate life-saving

assistance under a time-bound humanitarian tranche separated from unrelated strategic concessions. Procurement conditions should be open, competitive and tied only to delivery integrity. Beneficiary data should be minimal, purpose-limited, secured and controlled under recipient law, with no exclusive donor access. A joint board including recipient institutions, local communities and independent auditors should publish funds and outcomes while protecting personal data. Longer-term support should follow recipient-owned recovery priorities, use local procurement where feasible, build administrative and climate resilience, and include an exit and handover plan. Complaints, anti-corruption review and periodic renegotiation should be available to both parties. This compact preserves dual accountability without treating sovereignty as immunity from scrutiny or aid as a licence for coercion. Neutrality, proportionality, transparency and local agency make solidarity ethically credible.

**Q10. An investigative journalist uncovers a stone-mining mafia involving corrupt police and civil officials and a politically connected media owner, while inducement and pressure are used to suppress publication. Evaluate the options, ethical dilemmas and appropriate response. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.**

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (193 words; practice model, not official): The journalist faces truth and public interest against personal safety, source protection, confidentiality, editorial loyalty and the risk that premature publication may destroy evidence. Manjunath and Dubey warn that exposing a profitable network without protection can invite lethal retaliation. The first duty is therefore neither silence nor reckless heroism. He should authenticate permits, transport records, payments and communications; preserve encrypted copies in independent custody; document threats and inducements; obtain legal and trusted editorial review; and assess context-specific risk. A secure disclosure to a competent independent authority should precede or accompany carefully timed publication. Unrelated personal data and operational details should be minimised. MKSS and Parivartan show the power of transaction-level records and public verification, but the mining network also shows their limit where police, administration, politics and media ownership are captured. Escalation may require judicial protection or another legally competent forum. Publication should explain evidence and uncertainty, not pronounce guilt. The long-term remedy is network-focused: protect witnesses, reconcile extraction and royalty data, rotate captured posts, disclose ownership conflicts and create independent complaint routes. The qualified verdict is protected, evidence-led disclosure using the least harmful effective channel, followed by fair investigation and systemic repair.

**Q11. A State plans to link welfare, health and land databases to detect fraud and publish a district dashboard. As the responsible secretary, design an ethical information-sharing and transparency framework. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.**

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (264 words; practice model, not official): The proposal can detect duplicate claims and improve planning, but it combines distinct purposes and creates exclusion, profiling, breach and function-creep risks. Stakeholders include genuine beneficiaries, wrongly flagged families, officials, local bodies, data processors, auditors and the public. I would not authorise unrestricted linkage or publication. First, each exchange must identify legal authority, a specific fraud or planning purpose, necessary fields, data quality and a responsible officer. A documented sharing agreement should prohibit unrelated reuse, set role-based access, encryption, retention and deletion, preserve logs, require breach response and permit independent audit. High-risk matches should be treated as leads, never automatic grounds for benefit denial. Affected persons need notice where lawful, assisted correction, a speaking decision and prompt human appeal. Second, the public dashboard should use aggregation and suppression thresholds so citizens can compare allocation, delivery, pendency and grievance outcomes without exposing names, diagnoses or precise land identifiers. Methodology, update date, limitations and responsible office should be published. File-level records remain available through RTI subject to exemptions, severability and third-party procedure. Third, an oversight group including legal, security, programme and field expertise should test bias, false matches and access patterns. Periodic necessity review must terminate fields or linkages that do not improve the stated purpose. Procurement contracts should ensure portability and government audit access. Puttaswamy supplies the legality and proportionality discipline; data ethics adds minimisation and purpose limitation. The framework therefore separates restricted sharing from public disclosure, and connects both to answerability, correction and remedy. Fraud control is legitimate only when the information system does not make an innocent citizen transparent to an unaccountable State.

**Q12. A public-sector quality officer discovers that a safety-critical product failed tests, but senior management orders clearance to avoid losses and threatens retaliation. Decide. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.**

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (281 words; practice model, not official): Facts and dilemma: a failed safety result conflicts with management's commercial and reputational interests, and the officer faces personal retaliation. Stakeholders include consumers, workers, distributors, shareholders, the regulator, honest colleagues, management and the officer's family. Constraints include mandatory

safety standards, release deadlines, evidence custody, the officer's limited authority and the possibility that the ordinary reporting line is compromised. Options are: alter or ignore the result; delay silently; resign without reporting; or preserve the original test, record the oral direction, stop clearance within lawful authority and escalate with evidence to independent quality governance and, if required, the competent regulator. The first option fails legality, professional duty and public interest. Silent delay leaves the hazard active. Immediate resignation removes the witness and does not protect consumers. Decision: choose evidence preservation, written refusal and graduated escalation. Deontology requires fidelity to safety and truth; consequences favour preventing mass harm; virtue ethics supports courage disciplined by prudence. Steelman: a false or non-representative failed test could destroy the enterprise and jobs. Therefore an independent confirmatory test may proceed under controlled custody, but the product must remain quarantined until the competent authority decides; tests cannot be repeated selectively until a desired result appears. Implementation: timestamp and secure samples and raw data, request written confirmation, notify the independent quality committee, define a short regulator trigger, protect affected staff and prepare a truthful recall plan if distribution occurred. Communicate verified risk without sensationalism. Residual risk includes retaliation, evidence tampering and supply shortage. The regulator or independent quality head should control access logs, witness the retest, monitor the officer's employment treatment and audit corrective action. Resignation becomes defensible only if all lawful channels fail and continued office would require personal falsification.

**Q13. Edward Snowden, a computer expert and former CIA systems administrator, released confidential Government documents to the press about the existence of Government surveillance programmes. According to many legal experts and the US Government, his actions violated the Espionage Act of 1917, which identified the leak of State secrets as an act of treason. Yet, despite the fact that he broke the law, Snowden argued that he had a moral obligation to act. He gave a justification for his "whistle blowing" by stating that he had a duty "to inform the public as to that which is done in their name and that which is done against them." According to Snowden, the Government's violation of privacy had to be exposed regardless of legality since more substantive issues of social action and public morality were involved here. Many agreed with Snowden. Few argued that he broke the law and compromised national security, for which he should be held accountable. Do you agree that Snowden's actions were ethically justified even if legally prohibited? Why or why not? Make an argument by weighing the competing values in this case.**

[30 marks | 350 words]

Model answer (238 words; practice model, not official): Snowden's case is a conflict between privacy, informed democratic consent and public interest on one side, and legality, confidentiality, institutional loyalty and national security on the other. A moral claim cannot be dismissed merely because it challenges official secrecy; law may lag behind a serious wrong. Equally, private conscience cannot by itself licence disclosure of classified material. The ethical assessment should ask whether the alleged wrongdoing was evidence-based, whether authorised internal or oversight channels were realistically available, whether disclosure was necessary to avert serious public harm, and whether the material released was proportionate and minimised avoidable security or privacy damage. A deontological view emphasises duties of truth and confidentiality; consequential reasoning weighs democratic benefit against operational harm; virtue ethics asks whether courage was joined with prudence. For an Indian public servant, the safer institutional lesson is channel-first dissent: preserve evidence, record objection, use competent vigilance or oversight mechanisms and seek protection where available. External disclosure becomes ethically stronger only where internal remedies are inadequate and necessity is compelling. Thus the underlying concern may be morally serious, but ethical justification depends on method, proportionality and accountability, not conscience alone. A decision-maker should also distinguish disclosure of a public-interest concern from indiscriminate publication of every classified detail. Independent scrutiny, redaction and an opportunity to correct unlawful practice can protect both democratic accountability and legitimate security interests. The strongest conclusion is consequently conditional, not an unconditional celebration or condemnation of disclosure.

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS